

SketchUp revolutionises the translation of imagination into real 3D structures by making the process as intuitive as possible.

Most of the powerful 3D modelling software available in the market are extremely daunting at first glance (as we soon realised on trial). They also end up exacting a heavy toll on your wallet, something the beginner, or the casual user would obviously wish to avoid. Being both simplistic and most importantly, freeware, Google SketchUp overcomes both these hindrances. The quickly learnable, small yet versatile and powerful toolset allows the user to strike the right balance between sophistication and simplicity.

The workspace and the tools have been designed to be as intuitive to the user as possible. The intelligent interface ensures that even users with no prior experience in 3D modelling can quickly familiarise themselves with the Google SketchUp interface. The tools allow you to exercise simple, uninhibited freehand creativity, while the dimensions box, the measuring tape, etc. allow you to enforce strict dimensional accuracy.

With its emphasis on versatility and flexibility, Google SketchUp is the solution for the low-end 3D professional. For the architect, Google SketchUp offers features such as walkthroughs and projections. For the product designer and the engineer, views are easily available in orthographic and isometric modes. For the hobbyist, Google SketchUp provides the Google toolbar, his chance at showcasing his designs to the global community of Google Earth and Google Warehouse users.

But as they say, good things come in small packages. Despite its admirable arsenal of abilities, Google SketchUp comes in a small, freely downloadable freeware package of 31.7 MB. It is easy on your system resources, avoiding major headaches for the average user. You can download Google Sketchup from <http://SketchUp.google.com/download.html> or get it off this month's DVD.

1.1 You and Google SketchUp

So, let's get you introduced to the world of 3D modelling through Google SketchUp. You already know how useful Google SketchUp can be. It allows you to make sophisticated 3D models such as